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Liang Shi had no intention of questioning her at all, and her tone was even calm without any waves.

She was simply making an inquiry.

If it were Liang Wanwan being treated this way, would Qiu Zimin feel heartbroken? Would she be sad?

She certainly would.

But why, when it came to the original host, did Qiu Zimin have to go to such extremes?

Why did she have to use such cruel methods to treat a child?

From Qi Mama¹ to the sacrifice, every single incident had gone through Qiu Zimin's hands.

Qiu Zimin was even the primary instigator.

At this moment, Liang Shi felt heartbroken for the original host and felt it was unfair to her.

Perhaps when she was very young, she had also believed in Qiu Zimin, believed in this person called mother.

Perhaps she thought that as long as she was obedient, things would get better, but she never expected that obedience was just the first step pushing her into the abyss.

The original host's unpredictable personality was inseparable from Qiu Zimin's influence.

Even if Liang Shi hadn't transmigrated over, the original host might have become insane under Qiu Zimin's torment.

In the villa corridor with no one walking around, late at night in solitude, Liang Shi quietly looked at Qiu Zimin, but her hand gripped the railing tightly.

Not for any other reason, but because she was afraid Qiu Zimin might become desperate and directly push her down from upstairs.

This was purely for self-protection.

Unexpectedly, Qiu Zimin said: "What are you talking about? You and Wanwan are both my daughters. I could only treat Wanwan badly, but I've never treated you badly. Are you sleep-walking in the middle of the night?"

"Treating me well?" Liang Shi was genuinely surprised. How could she say these three words without any guilt?

"Do you still remember my previous room?" Liang Shi said: "Why did you change the things in my room?"

"You liked your original room?" Qiu Zimin asked.

Liang Shi sneered coldly, "Do you like coffins?"

Upon hearing this, Qiu Zimin's expression immediately changed, "How are you talking? How is that a coffin! Back then, it was because your health wasn't good that I went through great efforts to find someone to read your feng shui² and change the layout. Where did you hear such gossip?"

"I heard everything you said just now." Liang Shi lowered her eyes and smiled bitterly. In the end, she was still too impulsive, but it was also good to have everything out in the open like this. "You were talking to that person on Yunfeng Mountain, weren't you? When you took me to Yunfeng Mountain back then, what was it for? I'm afraid only you know clearly."

Liang Shi acted half-truthfully, "All these years, I've been a puppet in your hands. You hid from the family and turned my room into that ghostly appearance, making me live in a coffin room. I never had a good night's sleep. Are you very happy? I never understood why you treated me this way. Now I understand—because I'm not your daughter. You would never treat Wanwan like this."

Liang Shi had no memories related to parents.

She only had a pair of grandparents who loved her. When it rained, grandfather would go to the school gate to pick her up, and grandmother would cook ginger sugar water for her at home.

She had worn sweaters that grandmother knitted for her, and rode on grandfather's back to cross rivers.

Although she had never experienced parental love, she had her grandparents' love.

But what about the original host?

The original host had nothing.

She was surrounded by wolves, and had never truly experienced what love was.

Yet Qiu Zimin still shamelessly claimed that she treated the original host the best.

Was this being good? Was this love?

No.

It was just mental torture carried out under the guise of "love."

Moreover, the system had said that Liang Shi had been to this world before.

Although it didn't say when she came, Liang Shi guessed it was before age eight. Combined with her deep-rooted fear of Qi Mama, it was very likely that she had also suffered Qiu Zimin's abuse in her childhood.

After hearing such words, it was indeed difficult to remain calm.

Qiu Zimin originally wanted to keep pretending, but after hearing Liang Shi's words, she was too lazy to pretend anymore.

She sneered coldly, "So what? What do you want to do? Liang Shi, do you think your wings have grown hard enough to challenge me?"

"How could that be." Liang Shi smiled lightly, saying as if clouds were light and wind was gentle: "I just want to become a normal person."

"Normal person? How are you not normal?" Qiu Zimin said: "I give you money, food, clothing, let you be willful, more pampered than anyone around you, you can do whatever you want. Liang Shi, have you been living the good life for too long?"

Liang Shi didn't answer her words, just quietly stared at her.

And Qiu Zimin sneered: "Liang Shi, with your useless appearance, you can't accomplish anything if you leave the Liang family."

"Is that so?" Liang Shi said confidently: "Then let's wait and see."

"After you finish paying last month's credit card bill with the money you have on hand, you'll have nothing left, right?" Qiu Zimin had a superior attitude, "If you continue to listen to me and obediently be my daughter, I'll still treat you as well as before. You should know that in this circle, you're the most pampered."

Even at this point, she was still using both kindness and 威³.

"You should know that you have neither education nor ability. After leaving the Liang family, you'll lose all sources of income. We'll take back your villa, your bank cards. When you're penniless, Xu Qingzhu will also divorce you. You'll really have nothing left." Qiu Zimin's voice slowed down, as if earnestly advising: "You're my daughter, how could I harm you?"

"But am I really your daughter?" Liang Shi said: "You just admitted it. I'm not."

"How are you not?" Qiu Zimin's eyes widened, reflected by the dim light behind her, looking somewhat frightening, "As long as you listen to me, you are."

"But I've done a paternity test." Liang Shi bluffed, "I'm not yours and father's daughter."

Qiu Zimin: "..."

She sneered coldly, "But I've treated you as my biological daughter all these years."

It was a risky move, but the effect was good.

Liang Shi verified her guess.

She indeed wasn't Liang Father's illegitimate child either.

Footnotes: ¹ Qi Mama: This refers to Qi Jiao's mother, who was mentioned in earlier chapters as someone who abused both Liang Shi and Qi Jiao when they were children ² Feng shui: Traditional Chinese practice of arranging physical spaces to achieve harmony with spiritual forces ³ 威: This refers to the strategy of using both kindness (恩) and 威 (威 - authority/intimidation) to control someone

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Liang Shi smiled, "Is that so? Then why don't you arrange that kind of coffin room for Liang Wanwan too?"

Qiu Zimin's expression immediately changed, "Liang Shi, don't forget that you're still in the Liang family!"

Liang Shi nodded: "Yes, but why don't you dare let big brother and second brother know that I lived in such a coffin room? What are you afraid of?"

Qiu Zimin gritted her teeth, "What am I afraid of? I'm their mother! Even if they knew, what could they do to me? You're just trash I picked up, and I've supported you for so many years. What right do you have to question me now?!"

"If big brother and second brother saw what you've done, would your persona collapse?" Liang Shi curved her lips in a smile, acting out a few parts of evil with half truth and half pretense, "You're just trying to play a good mother in front of them, then torture me behind their backs."

"But when I came to the Liang family, I was only a few months old. Even if you were the one who found me, you could have completely treated me as a nanny's child, just giving me food so I wouldn't starve. Why did you scheme to make me your daughter, using love as an excuse to mentally control me, making me live worse than death, and even wanting to send me to a mental hospital?"

Liang Shi spoke at an unhurried pace, her tone steady, but filled with oppressive force.

Even though she stood one step lower than Qiu Zimin.

She still firmly held the upper hand.

After raising her doubts, she paused for a few seconds, then opened her mouth again to trick her, "You know my biological parents, don't you?"

During her speech, Qiu Zimin's expression grew worse and worse.

When she raised this question, Qiu Zimin immediately shouted loudly: "Get lost!"

This shout startled the birds kept on the villa's second floor, causing them to immediately flutter their wings and crash against the birdcage.

And all the room doors opened because of this shout.

The first to come out was Xu Qingzhu. She looked at the two people confronting each other on the stairs and immediately called out, "Liang Shi."

Liang Shi responded, instinctively comforting: "It's nothing."

Then came the Liang Xinhui couple living on the second floor, as well as the Liang Xinzhou couple who hurried up from the first floor.

Liang Xinhui was the first to speak: "What happened? Liang Shi, did you make mom angry again?"

Liang Xinzhou immediately said: "Ask clearly first, don't rush to conclusions."

They saw Qiu Zimin with two streams of clear tears flowing down, sliding across her cheeks.

"What's wrong?" Liang Xinzhou asked in a deep voice: "Why are you two fighting?"

Liang Shi looked at Qiu Zimin and chuckled lightly, "I have nothing to say. You all chat."

She didn't want to confront Qiu Zimin about everything that had happened here.

Liang Xinzhou and Liang Xinhui were still pretty good to her.

And regardless of how Qiu Zimin treated the original host, she was a qualified, even excellent mother to her other children.

Her children also respected her greatly.

To speak out about all this in front of the two brothers would be too cruel for the two brothers who had already started families and careers.

She had received kindness from others, so she wouldn't be ungrateful.

All this was just a conflict between her and Qiu Zimin.

Moreover, as long as she didn't completely break ties with the Liang family.

Liang Xinzhou and Liang Xinhui would still be her backup plan, although there was a 90% chance she wouldn't need it.

But what if?

Liang Shi felt that being human didn't require being utterly ruthless.

After Qiu Zimin saw her two sons, her tears flowed like a flood that had broken through a dam. Looking at Liang Shi with eyes that were as gentle as could be, as heartbroken as could be.

Sun Meirou immediately went forward to comfort her, "Mom, don't be angry. Shi is still young. If she said something wrong, just teach her. Don't cry yourself sick, you'll be the one suffering in the end."

"Liang Shi." Liang Xinhui stopped Liang Shi who was about to return to her room, "Explain clearly. After causing such a mess, saying you have nothing to say, you must give an explanation."

Liang Shi turned back, looking at Qiu Zimin from afar, her tone indifferent, "Are you sure you want me to speak?"

Qiu Zimin suddenly burst into loud crying, "Liang Shi, oh Liang Shi, I raised you for so many years, I never thought you were this kind of person! All these years I've treated you better than my own biological children, and this is how you treat me?"

—Treating you better than my own biological children.

Upon hearing this, Liang Xinhui and Liang Xinzhou immediately changed expressions.

"What do you mean?" Liang Xinhui was the first to lose composure, "Mom, what nonsense are you talking about?"

"At this point, I won't hide it from you either." Qiu Zimin cried and said: "Liang Shi is someone I picked up from outside back then. At that time I... I was too..."

Speaking to this point, she suddenly choked twice, then her eyes rolled back and she fell straight backward.

Fortunately, Sun Meirou was quick-eyed and fast-handed, supporting her waist, preventing her from falling on the stairs.

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Qiu Zimin ended this farce with fainting.

The atmosphere in the house became strange and tense. As the person involved, Liang Shi left the third-floor room after hearing that Qiu Zimin had only fainted from being too emotionally agitated.

She left the space to them.

She didn't care how Qiu Zimin would slander her.

Anyway, what the original host had left for everyone was never a positive image.

However, she should be able to move back to the original villa tomorrow, then go look for a house.

She probably wouldn't be able to stay in the Liang family much longer.

It depended on whether Qiu Zimin would completely tear off the facade.

After she left, Liang Xinzhou followed her out.

Liang Shi smiled bitterly, "Big brother, what's the matter?"

Liang Xinzhou glanced at her shoulder, paused for a few seconds before saying: "All these years, I've always treated you as my real little sister."

"Did you know I'm not a child of the Liang family?" Liang Shi suddenly asked him.

Liang Xinzhou pressed his lips together and told the truth: "I knew."

This surprised Liang Shi.

She wondered: "Then why are you still so good to me?"

She wasn't even a real sister.

This was being too sympathetic.

Liang Xinzhou stood there and said gently: "Let's go outside to talk."

Behind the villa was a large garden, where the gardener had trimmed it into various shapes.

Even in autumn, it was still full of blooming flowers.

However, autumn nights were cold. Liang Shi wrapped her coat tighter around herself but still sneezed.

Liang Xinzhou took off his own coat and handed it to her.

Liang Shi originally wanted to decline, but swallowed the words the second they were about to come out. She reached out to accept the coat, changing all her distant words into one sentence: "Thank you."

"I had a real little sister." Liang Xinzhou said: "The same age as you, not much different."

"But after father took her out, she was stolen when he got distracted and didn't watch her carefully. At that time, mom and dad's condition was very bad. We searched for a long time but couldn't find little sister. Until one day, mom brought you back from somewhere. You were even smaller than my little sister, but mom treated you as third little sister, and only then did the family atmosphere improve."

Liang Xinzhou was a steady person. When talking about these matters, he tried to narrate from an objective angle without deliberately favoring anyone.

"I know that mom and dad have been looking for third little sister all these years. But for me, you're someone who once saved our family, and you were only this big when you came to our house." Liang Xinzhou gestured with his hand, "Just a tiny bundle. To be honest, you're prettier than our family's third little sister. When Xinhui saw you, he kept clamoring to hold you. He was young then and didn't remember things, so he thought you were our real little sister."

Liang Shi listened to him talk about childhood events, and could picture the scenes in her mind.

"You were very well-behaved." Liang Xinzhou said: "You hardly ever cried or made a fuss. Ever since you came, Xinhui often said little sister had become well-behaved and didn't cry much anymore. And you loved to smile back then, your eyes would curve when you smiled."

"I watched you grow up from a few months old. I was the one who held your hand to practice walking, and I watched you learn to run. After you learned to speak, the first thing you called was 'brother'—I don't know if you were calling me or Xinhui." Mentioning these things, Liang Xinzhou's face showed a smile, "I was the one who sent you to kindergarten on your first day. The kindergarten teachers all praised how well-behaved you were."

"Later, although you became very rebellious, you were still very obedient at home." Liang Xinzhou said: "I would occasionally lament that my little sister had gone astray, mixing with those spoiled rich kids for no reason, but I never thought of not treating you as my sister. Moreover, recently my little sister's rebellious phase has passed, and she's become as well-behaved as when she was little. I'm very relieved."

"If possible, I hope you never have to know that you're not mom and dad's child in this lifetime." Liang Xinzhou said: "I would take this secret to my grave, even if my real little sister came back."

Listening to this, Liang Shi felt her nose tingle, and a tear fell.

She looked at Liang Xinzhou's profile, "Big brother, I once hoped for that too."

But Qiu Zimin was two-faced. If she didn't make things clear with her now, there would be endless troubles later.

She didn't want to live a life on tenterhooks.

Moreover, the original host had suffered so much injustice over the years—she deserved justice.

"So don't overthink it." Liang Xinzhou said: "You were our little sister before, and you'll still be our little sister in the future."

Liang Shi smiled, "I'm afraid mom doesn't think so."

Taking a walk, they returned to the villa entrance.

Liang Shi returned the coat to Liang Xinzhou, "Big brother, I can only say that mom's treatment of me isn't like what you see on the surface. If one day I sever ties with the Liang family, I'll still remember the kindness you and second brother showed me. I hope that even if we can't be siblings, we can still be friends."

Just, don't be enemies.

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When Liang Shi returned to her room, she was exhausted.

This kind of psychological fatigue spread to her body.

She leaned against the door to rest for quite a while before heavily exhaling, expelling all the bad emotions.

When she opened her eyes again, she found Xu Qingzhu looking at her.

"..."

"Are you alright?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Liang Shi nodded: "Unexpected, but reasonable."

"She's quite good at acting." Xu Qingzhu said flatly.

Although they had experienced such an incident tonight, after experiencing Qiu Zimin's matter, the two seemed to return to a time when they could get along peacefully. The atmosphere was finally not awkward anymore.

Liang Shi smiled helplessly, "If she couldn't act, how could everyone have been deceived by her for so many years."

Xu Qingzhu pressed her lips together, "Let me show you something."

Liang Shi turned her head, "What?"

Xu Qingzhu moved over, opened the bedside drawer, and took out what she had discovered in the room.

A blood-colored button, and a torn cloth doll.

Liang Shi frowned, "What is this?"

Xu Qingzhu said: "I found the button behind the door. There's human blood on it. This doll..."

She paused, flipping the doll over to reveal that the front of the doll's clothes was embroidered with two characters: Liang Shi.

And it was full of needles.

Xu Qingzhu said: "I found it in a corner under the bed."

Liang Shi: "..."

Just how superstitious was this Qiu Zimin?!

No, how much did she hate her?

"I suspect it's a kind of witchcraft." Xu Qingzhu said: "But I had a friend appraise it, and she said this was purely for venting anger, with no actual effect."

Liang Shi: "..."